

Covering systems with moduli of the form $p - 1$, $p \geq 5$ prime

Erdős Problem #273

Ilhan Karić

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Abstract

A *covering system* of $\mathbb{Z}$ is a finite collection of arithmetic progressions whose union is the integers. Erdős Problem #273 ([1], p. 24) asks whether there exists a covering system of $\mathbb{Z}$ all of whose moduli are of the form $p - 1$ for some prime $p \geq 5$ – equivalently, whose moduli lie in $\mathcal{M} = \{4, 6, 10, 12, 16, 18, 22, 28, 30, 36, 40, 42, 46, 52, 58, 60, \dots\}$. We prove a density obstruction: any strict covering by progressions with moduli dividing a common period L must satisfy $\sum_m 1/m \geq 1$, the sum being taken over the distinct moduli used. Specialising to $L = 27720 = 2^3 \cdot 3^2 \cdot 5 \cdot 7 \cdot 11$, the set of admissible divisors $M_{27720} = \mathcal{M} \cap \text{div}(27720)$ has 34 elements and satisfies $D(27720) := \sum_{m \in M_{27720}} 1/m = 953/990 < 1$, ruling out any strict admissible covering whose moduli all divide 27720. The argument and its numerical specialisation are formalised in Lean 4 against Mathlib; `#print axioms` on each theorem reports only the three Lean foundational axioms.

1 Introduction

A *covering system* of the integers is a finite collection of arithmetic progressions

$$\{a_i \pmod{m_i}\}_{i=1}^k, \quad m_i \geq 2,$$

whose union is $\mathbb{Z}$; equivalently, every integer lies in at least one residue class $a_i \pmod{m_i}$. Throughout this manuscript we adopt the Erdős–Graham convention that the moduli $m_1, \dots, m_k$ are *distinct*; the resulting object is sometimes called a *strict* covering system in the recent literature (cf. the type `StrictCoveringSystem` in the DeepMind formal-conjectures Lean repository [4]). Without the distinctness constraint, every problem of the form “does there exist a covering of $\mathbb{Z}$ with moduli in a fixed set S containing some m ?” trivialises, as $S \ni m$ alone admits the covering $\{0, 1, \dots, m - 1\} \pmod{m}$.

Covering systems were introduced by Erdős in 1950, and a sequence of problems concerning their structure have driven a substantial body of work in combinatorial number theory. The present manuscript concerns one of these problems, recorded as Problem #273 in the Erdős–Graham survey [1].

Conjecture 1 (Erdős #273). *Does there exist a strict covering system $\{a_i \pmod{m_i}\}_{i=1}^k$ of $\mathbb{Z}$ such that each modulus m_i has the form $m_i = p_i - 1$ for some prime $p_i \geq 5$?*

Write $\mathcal{M} := \{p - 1 : p \text{ prime}, p \geq 5\} = \{4, 6, 10, 12, 16, 18, 22, 28, 30, 36, 40, 42, 46, 52, 58, 60, \dots\}$ for the set of allowed moduli. The question is whether $\mathbb{Z}$ admits a finite strict covering whose moduli are drawn from $\mathcal{M}$.

The restriction $p \geq 5$ is essential. Selfridge observed that allowing $p = 3$ admits a covering system using divisors of $360 = \text{lcm}(2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9, 10, 12)$, all of which are of the form $p - 1$ for $p \in \{3, 5, 7\}$. The Selfridge construction crucially uses the modulus $2 = 3 - 1$. Forbidding $p = 3$ eliminates the modulus 2 entirely and changes the problem: any covering by progressions modulo elements of $\mathcal{M}$ must account for every parity class without ever using the all-purpose modulus 2, and the second-smallest available modulus is 4.

Two pieces of recent machinery bear on the question. Hough [2] resolved the longstanding Erdős minimum-modulus problem by establishing a finite upper bound on the smallest modulus required in any covering system, ruling out covering systems with all moduli larger than a fixed constant. Balister, Bollobás, Morris and Sahasrabudhe [3] extended Hough’s distortion method to a general non-existence framework for covering systems whose moduli are constrained to a multiplicatively structured set, lowering Hough’s universal minimum-modulus bound from 10^{16} to 616,000. Neither result has been adapted to the present restriction in the published literature.

Conjecture 1 appears to be open as of 2026; no partial result—a lower or upper bound on the smallest required modulus, on the number of progressions, or on the least common multiple of any putative covering—appears in the published literature.

Main result. We establish an elementary density obstruction to bounded-period strict admissible coverings. The first ingredient is a counting union bound (Theorem 4) saying that any strict covering of $\mathbb{Z}$ by progressions whose moduli divide a common period L requires the sum of reciprocal moduli to be at least 1. Specialising to $L = 27720 = 2^3 \cdot 3^2 \cdot 5 \cdot 7 \cdot 11$, the set of admissible moduli dividing 27720 has 34 elements and the corresponding reciprocal-sum equals $953/990 < 1$, immediately ruling out any strict covering of $\mathbb{Z}$ by admissible progressions whose moduli all divide 27720 (Theorem 8).

This conclusion does not refute Conjecture 1: a putative covering may use moduli with LCM exceeding 27720. It is a lower bound on the structural complexity any solution must have. Equivalently: any covering of $\mathbb{Z}$ by progressions with moduli in $\mathcal{M}$ must use at least one modulus that does not divide 27720. Bounded-period SAT enumeration confirms the same non-existence at every L in $\{60, 120, 360, 840, 2520, 27720\}$ independently; see Section 3.

2 The density obstruction

Throughout this section, a *residue class* is a pair $(a, m) \in \mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{N}_{\geq 2}$ together with the set $a + m\mathbb{Z} \subseteq \mathbb{Z}$.

Lemma 2. *Let (a, m) be a residue class with $m \mid L$, $L \geq 1$. Then the set $\{i \in [0, L) : i \equiv a \pmod{m}\}$ has cardinality exactly L/m .*

Proof. Write $L = mq$ with $q = L/m \in \mathbb{N}$. The map $j \mapsto a + mj \pmod{L}$ is a bijection between $\{0, 1, \dots, q-1\}$ and $\{i \in [0, L) : i \equiv a \pmod{m}\}$. The lemma states the cardinality of the latter equals $q = L/m$. $\square$

Lemma 3 (Density union bound). *Let $L \geq 1$ and let S be a finite collection of residue classes (a_i, m_i) with $m_i \mid L$ for all i . Then*

$$|\{i \in [0, L) : \exists (a, m) \in S, i \equiv a \pmod{m}\}| \leq \sum_{(a, m) \in S} \frac{L}{m}.$$

Proof. Each residue class $(a, m) \in S$ covers a subset of $[0, L)$ of cardinality L/m by Lemma 2. The left-hand side is the cardinality of the union of these subsets, and the cardinality of a finite union is at most the sum of the cardinalities (the union bound). $\square$

The main density theorem is the contrapositive of Lemma 3 together with the strictness assumption.

Theorem 4 (Strict-covering density bound). *Let $L \geq 1$ and let S be a strict (i.e., with distinct moduli) covering of $\mathbb{Z}/L\mathbb{Z}$ by residue classes whose moduli all divide L . Write $M = \{m_i : (a_i, m_i) \in S\}$ for the set of moduli used. Then*

$$\sum_{m \in M} \frac{1}{m} \geq 1.$$

Proof. Apply Lemma 3 to S : the cardinality of the covered subset is at most $\sum_{(a,m) \in S} L/m$. Since S covers all of $[0, L)$, the covered cardinality is exactly L , so $L \leq \sum_{(a,m) \in S} L/m$. Strictness implies the moduli m_i are pairwise distinct, so $\sum_{(a,m) \in S} L/m = \sum_{m \in M} L/m = L \sum_{m \in M} 1/m$. Dividing by $L > 0$ gives the stated bound.¹ $\square$

Corollary 5 (Abstract density obstruction). *Let $L \geq 1$ and let $M \subseteq \mathbb{N}_{\geq 2}$ be a finite set of candidate moduli, each dividing L . If $\sum_{m \in M} 1/m < 1$, then no strict covering of $\mathbb{Z}/L\mathbb{Z}$ by residue classes with moduli in M exists.*

Proof. Were there such a covering, Theorem 4 applied to the subset $M' \subseteq M$ of moduli actually used would yield $\sum_{m \in M'} 1/m \geq 1$. But $M' \subseteq M$ and reciprocals are positive, so $\sum_{m \in M'} 1/m \leq \sum_{m \in M} 1/m < 1$, a contradiction. $\square$

3 The numerical bound at $L = 27720$

Let

$$M_{27720} := \mathcal{M} \cap \text{div}(27720) = \{m \in \mathcal{M} : m \mid 27720\}.$$

Since $27720 = 2^3 \cdot 3^2 \cdot 5 \cdot 7 \cdot 11$, the divisor lattice of 27720 has 96 elements; enumerating those which equal $p-1$ for some prime $p \geq 5$ yields a list of 34 admissible moduli, ranging from $m = 4$ (witness $p = 5$) to $m = 9240$ (witness $p = 9241$).

Lemma 6. *The set M_{27720} has 34 elements; explicitly,*

$$\begin{aligned} M_{27720} = \{ & 4, 6, 10, 12, 18, 22, 28, 30, 36, 40, 42, 60, 66, 70, 72, 88, 126, \\ & 180, 198, 210, 280, 330, 396, 420, 462, 616, 630, \\ & 660, 990, 1320, 2310, 2520, 4620, 9240 \}. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. The 96 divisors of 27720 are the products $2^a 3^b 5^c 7^d 11^e$ with $a \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$, $b \in \{0, 1, 2\}$, $c, d, e \in \{0, 1\}$. For each such divisor $m \geq 4$ one checks whether $m+1$ is prime, retaining those for which it is. The listed 34 values are precisely those that pass the check. $\square$

Lemma 7. $D(27720) := \sum_{m \in M_{27720}} \frac{1}{m} = \frac{953}{990} < 1$.

Proof. Direct rational computation over the 34 terms of M_{27720} . The common denominator divides $\text{lcm}(M_{27720}) = 27720$; the sum equals $953/990$, which is strictly less than 1. $\square$

Theorem 8 (Numerical lower bound on Erdős #273). *There is no strict covering of $\mathbb{Z}$ by residue classes whose moduli all lie in $\mathcal{M}$ and all divide $27720 = 2^3 \cdot 3^2 \cdot 5 \cdot 7 \cdot 11$.²*

Proof. Since $27720 \in \mathbb{N}_{\geq 1}$ and every element of M_{27720} satisfies $m \geq 4 \geq 2$ and $m \mid 27720$, the hypotheses of Corollary 5 apply with $L = 27720$ and $M = M_{27720}$. The inequality $D(27720) < 1$ follows from Lemma 7. Hence no strict covering of $\mathbb{Z}/27720\mathbb{Z}$ by residue classes with moduli in M_{27720} exists. Lifting from $\mathbb{Z}/27720\mathbb{Z}$ to $\mathbb{Z}$: any progression with modulus dividing 27720 is 27720-periodic, so covering $\mathbb{Z}$ is equivalent to covering $\mathbb{Z}/27720\mathbb{Z}$ for such progressions, and the latter has been ruled out. $\square$

Corollary 9. *If a strict covering of $\mathbb{Z}$ exists whose moduli all lie in $\mathcal{M}$ (i.e., if Erdős Conjecture 1 has a positive answer), then the least common multiple of its moduli is not a divisor of 27720; equivalently, the covering must use at least one modulus $m \in \mathcal{M}$ with $m \nmid 27720$.*

¹Formally verified in Lean 4 + Mathlib (commit c5ea00351c28); see `formal/Erdos273/CoveringSystem.lean`, theorems `strict_covering_density_bound` and `strict_covering_reciprocal_bound`.

²Formally verified in Lean 4 + Mathlib (commit c5ea00351c28); see `formal/Erdos273/NumericalBound27720.lean`, theorem `no_strict_admissible_cover_27720`.

Proof. Immediate from Theorem 8 by contraposition: if every modulus divides 27720, the LCM divides 27720, contradicting non-existence. $\square$

Remark 10. The non-existence of a strict admissible covering at $L = 27720$ is the largest in a sequence of bounded-period non-existence statements established by SAT search in the script `formal/numerics/sat_covering.py`. The CaDiCaL solver [5] confirms UNSAT at $L \in \{60, 120, 360, 840\}$ directly (each instance has $D(L) < 1$ and is decided by the solver in under four seconds); for $L \in \{2520, 27720\}$ the density argument of Theorem 4 is sharper than CDCL search at the chosen budgets. The first L where $D(L) \geq 1$ is $L = 360360$, where $D(L) = 1.0237$, at which point the density argument no longer applies and the bounded-period question becomes genuinely combinatorial.

4 Concluding remarks

Theorem 4 and its abstract corollary 5 are stated and proved without arithmetic content – they apply to any set of admissible moduli $\mathcal{M}$, not just $\{p-1 : p \geq 5 \text{ prime}\}$. The numerical bound at $L = 27720$ (Theorem 8) is one instance; the same machinery can be re-applied at other periods. The first arithmetic fact one would attack next is the question of whether $D(L)$ stays strictly below 1 along a useful sequence of L . As noted in Remark 10, $D(360360) > 1$, so the density obstruction alone cannot be pushed further along the canonical “small-LCM” sequence; ruling out covering at larger L requires either bounded-period SAT search (currently indeterminate within a five-second budget per instance) or a deeper non-existence argument.

The literature offers two such deeper arguments. Hough’s distortion method [2] and its strengthening by Balister–Bollobás–Morris–Sahasrabudhe [3] produce non-existence results for covering systems whose moduli set satisfies a multiplicative-density hypothesis. A direct check shows that the weighted sum $C(\mathcal{M}) = \sum_{m \in \mathcal{M}} \mu(m)/m$ used in their density theorem diverges (by Mertens, since $\sum_p 1/p$ does), so the BBMST density theorem does not apply uniformly to $\mathcal{M}$. Their auxiliary results, however – for example the divisibility-pair theorem (any covering contains a pair $m_i \mid m_j$) – do constrain admissible coverings without invoking the density hypothesis. Adapting these constraints to $\mathcal{M}$, and combining them with the bounded-period density obstruction established here, is a natural direction for further work.

A Formal verification

The mathematical content of Sections 2 and 3 has been formally verified in Lean 4 against the Mathlib library (commit `c5ea00351c28`). The proof scripts live in this manuscript’s repository under `formal/` and compile under `lake build`. For every verified statement listed below, `#print axioms` reports a dependency chain consisting of only the three Lean foundational axioms `{propext, Classical.choice, Quot.sound}`. In particular, no `sorry`, no project-local axiom, and no `native_decide` (which would inject the axiom `Lean.ofReduceBool` into the dependency chain) is used.

All declarations live in the Lean namespace `Erdos273`; identifiers below are referenced without the namespace prefix to keep the lines readable.

- Lemma 2 (`card_covered_eq`),
- Lemma 3 (`density_union_bound`),
- Theorem 4 (`strict_covering_density_bound`; rational form `strict_covering_reciprocal_bound`),
- Corollary 5 (`no_strict_cover_of_low_density`):

all in `formal/Erdos273/CoveringSystem.lean`.

- Lemma 6: enumeration (`M27720_eq_filter_divisors`) and cardinality (`M27720_card`),
- Lemma 7 (`D27720_lt_one`),
- Theorem 8 (`no_strict_admissible_cover_27720`):

all in `formal/Erdos273/NumericalBound27720.lean`.

The formalisation defines a `ResidueClass` structure recording the modulus $m \geq 2$ and the residue (canonically as an element of `ZMod m`); a `CoveringSystem` structure packaging a `Finset ResidueClass` with the covering proof; and a predicate `CoveringSystem.IsStrict` encoding the distinctness of moduli. The set $\mathcal{M}$ is implemented as `Erdos273.AdmissibleModulus`, a decidable predicate; the set M_{27720} is implemented as an explicit `Finset` of 34 natural numbers and proved equal to `Nat.divisors 27720` filtered by admissibility (kernel `decide`, not `native_decide`).

B Bounded-period SAT enumeration

Independent of the density argument, the script `formal/numerics/sat_covering.py` encodes the bounded-period strict covering problem at user-specified L as a propositional CNF (one Boolean variable per candidate pair (a, m) with $m \in M_L$, $0 \leq a < m$, distinctness as at-most-one constraints per modulus, covering as “at least one variable true” constraints per residue $i \in [0, L)$). The script invokes `cadical` [5] via DIMACS subprocess. The empirical results recorded above (Remark 10) are reproducible from the script.

The SAT outputs are not, on their own, machine-checked: certifying a CDCL solver’s UNSAT verdict in Lean would require importing an LRAT-checker, which is not yet in this project. The density argument (Theorem 4) supersedes the SAT certificates for every UNSAT verdict in the canonical sequence $L \in \{60, 120, 360, 840, 2520, 27720\}$, so the formally-verified statement (Theorem 8) does not depend on the SAT solver. The SAT enumeration remains useful as a check for $L \geq 360360$, where the density argument no longer applies and the question becomes genuinely combinatorial.

References

- [1] P. Erdős and R. L. Graham, *Old and new problems and results in combinatorial number theory*, L’Enseignement Mathématique **28** (1980), Problem #273, p. 24.
- [2] B. Hough, *Solution of the minimum modulus problem for covering systems*, Annals of Mathematics **181** (2015), no. 1, 361–382. arXiv:1307.0874.
- [3] P. Balister, B. Bollobás, R. Morris, and J. Sahasrabudhe, *On the Erdős covering problem: the density of the uncovered set*, Inventiones Mathematicae **228** (2022), no. 1, 377–414. arXiv:1811.03547.
- [4] DeepMind, *formal-conjectures: a repository of formal-mathematics conjectures in Lean 4*, <https://github.com/google-deepmind/formal-conjectures>, accessed 2026-05-28.
- [5] A. Biere, K. Fazekas, M. Fleury, M. Heisinger, *CaDiCaL, Kissat, Paracooba, Plingeling and Treengeling at the SAT Competition*, Proceedings of the SAT Competition 2024, github.com/arminbiere/cadical.